

inspection reveals something much more remarkable. The exterior is loosely sheathed with fruit-tree branches, arranged vertically. The frame of the fully glazed building is steel, but inside wood again dominates, with strong uprights crossed by beams—a pattern continued on the roof. The split-level, partly stepped floor is similarly made of wood. There are no chairs or tables, just rectangular cushions. Throughout, diffused light plays through the exterior cladding. Completed in 2011, Liyuan Library represents the simple made memorable.

Ryugyong Hotel

Location Pyongyang, North Korea

The Ryugyong Hotel is a vast pyramidal skyscraper that dominates the cityscape of Pyongyang, the capital of North

Korea. Comprising 105 floors and reaching 1,080 ft (330 m) high, the building is the country's tallest structure. It consists of three wings that rise jaggedly at an angle of 75 degrees and are capped by a cone-shaped structure formed by a series of concentric rings. Its construction began in 1987 and was due to be finished by 1992. However, by 1992, it was still incomplete and work was suspended. Construction resumed in 2008 and continued until 2013, by which point the exterior was more or less complete. In 2018, a huge LED display was added to one side of the building.

Heydar Aliyev Center

Location Baku, Azerbaijan

The sweeping curves and flowing spaces that mark so much of Iraqi-British architect Zaha Hadid's work reach perhaps their ultimate

expression in her Heydar Aliyev Center, completed in 2013. The huge building, 243 ft (74 m) tall at its highest, is a convention center, library, and museum—its forms melting and merging into one another. It is enclosed in white, almost wavelike shapes that reach rhythmically skyward and fold in on themselves. Openings are filled with huge expanses of bronze-tinted glass that glow dramatically at night. The interior is no less dynamically curvilinear, displaying a kind of fluid geometry with almost no straight lines. The building stands in absolute contrast to the rigid monumentality of Soviet-era Baku.

House for Trees

Location Ho Chi Minh City, Vietnam

In a city with almost no trees or parks left because of rapid urbanization, the House for Trees,

designed by Vietnamese firm Vo Trong Nghia (VTN) Architects and completed in 2014, is an ingenious means of reintroducing greenery while producing a low-cost, simple-to-build house. In fact, the house consists of five separate, two-story structures, grouped irregularly around a courtyard, with their upper levels linked by open bridges. They are built of concrete that is patterned to resemble bamboo. The interior walls feature plain exposed brick. All sections have large, airy windows, but what most distinguishes them is that they are, in effect, huge flower pots. From their strengthened roofs rise substantial trees. They also function as storm-water basins during heavy rains, helping reduce flooding in the city's narrow streets. In one stroke, an otherwise unrelieved and polluted urban environment is suddenly transformed.

